in democracies in so many places today.'[136] How exactly did we come to that? Let's look at the Hungarian and Polish case first.

Paul Lendvai is an Austrian journalist of Hungarian descent, a Social Democrat who fled to Austria after the suppression of the Hungarian uprising in 1956. In his book *Orbán: Europe's New Strongman*, he does not skimp on criticism of the Hungarian Prime Minister and describes with passion and concern for his native country Orbán's rise to what is now seen as a near-total power, a capture of the state.

Interestingly enough and as Lendvai points out, nothing in Orbán's childhood indicated his later anti-communist mood; the family was apparently a conformist one. A bold move, however, was the founding of Fidesz in 1988 at a student college in Budapest. Orbán's then student colleagues are still his closest allies, and almost without exception they come from very modest rural circles, not liberal or leftist Budapest elites, who looked down on them – an experience that has supposedly left a strong mark on Orbán and has dictated his later political credo.[137]

The party was successful in the first democratic election (Orbán was the first to publicly call for the withdrawal of Soviet troops from Hungary at a major rally – it was this that gave him prominence), but was defeated in the following elections in 1994. Hungary then came to be ruled by a coalition of the former communist Socialist party ('a snake pit of old Communists and left wing careerists posing as Social Democrats'[138]) and the new Free Democrats party. But a year later, Orbán drove his hitherto liberal (sometimes even anti-church) Fidesz to the right and won his first term as Prime Minister in 1998. The results of his tenure were a significant statutory and public sector wage increase and generous incentives for private housing, unsupported by the state of public finances – all these laid the foundations for Hungary's economic debacle in 2002-2010, for which, however, the subsequent coalition of Socialists and Free Democrats would be mostly responsible.[139]

The government of Socialist Prime Minister Medgyessy was then overthrown in 2002 following the publication of a news piece in an opposition newspaper, claiming that he had been an agent of the Communist Secret Police. He was succeeded by Mr Gyurcsany, considered by Lendvai to be Hungary's 'most capable, controversial and unpredictable (and certainly richest) politician on the left',[140] who managed to